WEEK 5 · LECTURE L1 · UNIT II

Digital Onboarding: From Documents to Belonging

From signal to belonging: how organizations select, why paperwork is the easy part of onboarding, and what socialization theory says the hard part is.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

1. Explain hiring as two way signaling, why validity governs a screen’s value, and how models trained on the past copy it (ASA; Barocas and Selbst).
2. Explain onboarding as socialization: Van Maanen and Schein’s tactics, Bauer et al.’s three adjustments, information seeking and the psychological contract.
3. Apply Bauer’s four Cs and three levels, and design onboarding for frontline and corporate joiners.
4. Evaluate India Stack onboarding, including the Puttaswamy judgment and DPDP limits.

ONE SOURCE

The same theories as the in class lecture and the course hub, without the simulation data used in class. Course outcomes: CLO 2 and CLO 5.

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Commit to an answer first

A Gurugram fintech cuts onboarding paperwork from five days to one hour with DigiLocker and eSign. A year later, first year attrition is unchanged. What best explains this?

A

The digital tools were badly configured

B

Paperwork was never the main driver of early exit; newcomer adjustment is

C

Pay for new joiners was below market

D

Young employees dislike digital processes

EXAM LENS

The answer is B. The rest of the lecture explains what newcomer adjustment is and how to build it.

ULRICH AND SMALLWOOD (2012)

Talent is a product of three Cs, not a sum

Competence

Can do: the knowledge, skills and values the job needs now and in future.

Commitment

Will do: the effort and energy a person chooses to give.

Contribution

Wants to do: meaning and purpose in the work, so effort lasts.

EXAM LENS

Talent = competence × commitment × contribution. If any one is zero, talent is zero. A course score measures, at most, part of competence.

FROM SIGNAL TO SELECTION

Hiring is a two way signaling problem

The employer reads the candidate

Spence (1973): when quality is hidden, employers rely on costly signals such as degrees and experience. An ATS turns signals into keywords and cut offs.

The candidate reads the employer

Rynes, Bretz and Gerhart (1991): applicants treat delays, tone and process quality as signals of how the firm treats people. A silent auto rejection is also a signal.

A screen is only as useful as its validity

Taylor and Russell (1939): a selection tool adds value through validity, the selection ratio and the base rate of good performers together. Ask what the tool’s validity is against later performance, and who measured it.

WHY SCREENING MODELS COPY THE PAST

The ASA cycle, two kinds of fit, and five routes to disparate impact

ASA (Schneider, 1987)

Similar people apply, the firm picks people like current staff, those who do not fit leave, and the workforce narrows.

Two kinds of fit (Kristof, 1996)

Person organization fit (values) differs from person job fit (skills). A model trained on past hires learns both, mixed together.

Route (Barocas and Selbst, 2016)	How it enters a screen
1 · Target variable	“Good hire” defined as long tenure, favoring groups with fewer career breaks
2 · Labeled examples	Past offers, already skewed, used as the answer key
3 · Feature selection	Fields that exist for some applicants and not others
4 · Proxies	A career gap or college name stands in for gender or class
5 · Masking	A deliberately biased choice hidden in a neutral looking model

EXAM LENS

Naming the route is more analytical than saying “the algorithm is biased”. Candidates also judge the process: a typical ATS fails Gilliland’s feedback and two way communication rules.

ONBOARDING IS ORGANIZATIONAL SOCIALIZATION

Van Maanen and Schein (1979): six choices every design makes

Institutionalized (more certainty)	Individualized (more room to shape the role)
Collective: a cohort together	Individual: one person at a time
Formal: a separate program	Informal: learning on the job
Sequential: a set order of steps	Random: no set order
Fixed: a known timetable	Variable: an open timetable
Serial: an experienced insider as role model	Disjunctive: no role model
Investiture: affirming the newcomer’s identity	Divestiture: reshaping it

EXAM LENS

Jones (1986): institutionalized tactics produce less role ambiguity and more commitment; individualized tactics produce more role innovation. Socialization happens whether designed or not.

BAUER ET AL. (2007)

What onboarding must produce: three adjustments

Antecedents

Newcomer information seeking; institutionalized socialization tactics.

Adjustment

Role clarity: I know what my job is. Self efficacy: I can do it. Social acceptance: I am accepted here.

Outcomes

Performance, job satisfaction, commitment, intention to remain, lower turnover.

EXAM LENS

Measure the middle box. Completing onboarding tasks is an input, not an outcome; paperwork that builds none of the three adjustments does not deliver the outcomes.

NEWCOMERS REDUCE UNCERTAINTY

Information seeking

Uncertainty reduction

Berger and Calabrese (1975): people in new relationships act to make others predictable; newcomers do the same with the organization.

Seeking tactics

Miller and Jablin (1991): overt and indirect questions, third parties, testing limits, observing. A chatbot serves only the first.

What they seek

Morrison (1993): technical, role, normative, performance feedback and social information. Normative and social answers come from people.

ROUSSEAU (1989; 1995)

Onboarding writes the psychological contract

The contract

Beliefs about mutual promises, held by the employee: transactional (pay for work) or relational (loyalty, growth).

Early breach

Robinson and Rousseau (1994): a majority of new graduates reported a broken promise within two years; breach predicted lower trust and higher exit.

Realistic previews

Premack and Wanous (1985): previews lower inflated expectations; the effect on retention is small but reliable.

BAUER (2010)

The four Cs, and how far digital tools reach

C	What it covers	Digital tools
Compliance	Rules, forms, legal and policy requirements	Excellent
Clarification	The job, how it is measured, what success looks like	Good
Culture	Norms and values, formal and informal	Needs people
Connection	Relationships and networks that create belonging	Needs people

EXAM LENS

Three levels: passive (mostly compliance, some clarification: a checklist), high potential (compliance and clarification done well, some culture and connection), proactive (all four built in, followed through the first year). Most digital programs stop at passive: the newcomer is processed, not integrated. The teaching note’s four areas (administrative, social, cultural, role specific) say the same.

Reach column: Course framing.

SYNTHESIS

Four onboarding frameworks, four units of analysis

Framework	What it describes	What it misses
Van Maanen and Schein (1979)	How the organization structures entry (tactics)	The newcomer’s own seeking
Bauer (2010), four Cs	What content onboarding covers	How content is delivered
Klein and Polin (2012)	Concrete practices: inform, welcome, guide	Outcomes in the newcomer
Bauer et al. (2007)	Adjustment states and outcomes	Specific practices to use

EXAM LENS

Use a process framework to design onboarding and an outcome model to evaluate it. Mixing them up is a common error.

THEORY IN DEPTH · CABLE, GINO AND STAATS (2013)

Let newcomers bring themselves to work

The core idea

A field experiment at Wipro’s call centers in India compared onboarding that stressed the firm’s identity with onboarding that stressed newcomers’ own strengths.

How it works

Newcomers asked to share what they do best showed higher retention and customer satisfaction months later.

Limits and critique

One firm and one job type; results may differ elsewhere.

IN PRACTICE

A first week mobile flow could ask each new hire, in their own language, what they are good at. It costs almost nothing.

EXAM LENS

An Indian field experiment is strong evidence in an exam answer; note its generalizability limit.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BANDURA (1977)

Belief in your ability predicts whether you try

The core idea

Self efficacy is confidence that you can perform a specific task.

How it works

Four sources: mastery experiences, watching peers succeed, verbal encouragement, and physiological state under stress.

Limits and critique

Efficacy is task specific; confidence in one app does not automatically transfer.

IN PRACTICE

An easy first self service task, demonstrated by a peer from the same workplace, builds efficacy faster than a manual.

EXAM LENS

Link self efficacy to Bauer et al.’s adjustments: it is one of the three.

INDIA STACK IN ONBOARDING

What it offers, and its limits

What it offers

DigiLocker: documents issued from the source, no photocopies. Aadhaar eKYC: identity in minutes. eSign: offer letters and declarations signed online with an audit trail. UPI and a bank check for the first salary.

The legal limit

Puttaswamy (2018) upheld Aadhaar for welfare schemes but struck down Section 57 so far as it let private bodies demand Aadhaar authentication by contract. Employers should offer alternative identity documents. The DPDP Act adds purpose, minimal collection, limited retention and safeguards.

The access limit

Every rail assumes a working phone, data and skill. A feature phone user cannot use DigiLocker on that phone; an assisted route may be more realistic than self service.

EXAM LENS

India Stack completes compliance: it removes the document chase and does nothing for clarification, culture or connection.

DESIGN

Frontline and corporate onboarding are different journeys

	Corporate joiner	Frontline joiner
Device	Laptop and email on day one	Own smartphone, often with limited data, or a feature phone
Language	English portal works	Regional language, voice first
Documents	Upload and eSign	DigiLocker, eKYC and eSign from the phone, often with help
First weeks	Structured program, systems access, a manager’s ninety day plan	On the floor in shifts, short mobile modules, a named buddy on the shift
Success measure	Time to productivity	Still in the job, and adjusted, at 90 days

EXAM LENS

The channel changes with the workforce; the three adjustments do not. Apply cognitive load theory (Sweller, 1988): build the first month as a staircase, with progressive disclosure, not a day one information dump. Measure role clarity and social acceptance at day 30.

APPLY

Six hundred nursing aides a year

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Lucknow hospital chain hires about 600 nursing aides a year, most from small towns in Uttar Pradesh. A new app collects documents through DigiLocker and requires Aadhaar eKYC before day one. Joining is now fast, yet a third of aides leave within ninety days, often saying they did not know whom to ask for help on night shifts.

Work it through

1. Which of the four Cs does the app serve, and which does it ignore?
2. Which of the three adjustments is failing, on the evidence given?
3. Which socialization tactic would you add, and why?
4. What is wrong with making Aadhaar eKYC compulsory?

COMMON CONFUSIONS

Tempting readings, and better ones

A tempting reading	A better reading
Faster paperwork means better onboarding	Onboarding works through role clarity, self efficacy and social acceptance
A digital portal can replace the buddy	Connection and culture need people; the serial tactic is a person, not a feature
Aadhaar verification can be required of every joiner	Puttaswamy (2018) limits private demands; offer alternatives
The algorithm is biased	Name the route: target, labels, features, proxies or masking

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Lenses on joining an organization

Lens	Use it to	Watch out for
Spence; Rynes et al.	Read hiring as two way signaling	Signals are not validity
ASA; Barocas and Selbst	Explain how models copy the past	Masking is hard to prove
Van Maanen and Schein	Design entry tactics	Ignores the newcomer’s seeking
Bauer et al. (2007)	Evaluate adjustment	Says little about practices
Psychological contract	Anticipate early breach	Beliefs are hard to observe *
Cable et al. (2013)	Use strengths in onboarding	One firm, one job

* Course framing.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse (1 of 2)

A Pune engineering firm has digitized its onboarding with DigiLocker, eSign and an app, yet early attrition is unchanged. Using socialization tactics, the four Cs and the evidence on newcomer adjustment, diagnose the problem and redesign the first ninety days. Note one legal limit. **20 marks**

A strong answer: names the tactics used and missing; shows the app serves compliance only; uses the three adjustments as the test of the redesign; states the Aadhaar and DPDP limits.

“Onboarding is socialization, not paperwork.” Critically discuss using Van Maanen and Schein, Bauer et al. (2007) and the psychological contract. **20 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes tactics, content and outcomes; uses the three adjustments; explains early breach; evaluates digital onboarding’s limits for culture and connection.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse (2 of 2)

Explain how a hiring algorithm can produce disparate impact without any intent to discriminate. **20 marks**

A strong answer: uses the ASA cycle and Barocas and Selbst’s five routes with an HR example of each; proposes audits.

What can India Stack do for onboarding, and what can it not do? **10 marks**

A strong answer: explains eKYC, DigiLocker and eSign; notes Puttaswamy and DPDP purpose limitation; argues it covers compliance but not culture or connection.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Four things to remember

1. **Hiring is two way signaling.**
   The process signals to candidates as much as the CV signals to employers.

2. **Models trained on the past copy the past.**
   Name the route by which bias enters.

3. **Measure adjustment, not task completion.**
   Role clarity, self efficacy, social acceptance.

4. **A checklist completes onboarding for the HRIS.**
   Only connection completes it for the person.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this week

- Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020), pp. 83 to 84 (new models of education and workplace learning).
- Case: Infosys Lex, digital reskilling at scale.
- NASSCOM FutureSkills (latest), selected sections.

NOTE

The other works named in this lecture are theory sources for reference, not set readings.

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